

CalmSignal: Early Meltdown Warning & Facial Action Observation Kit

Autonomic Arousal Checklist to Intercept Sensory Overload | Framework: Pediatric Autonomic Regulation & Computer-Vision Clinical Markers

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Clinical Resource Packet

CHILD'S NAME	AGE / GRADE	DATE	COMPLETED BY

The 3 Physiological Stages of Impending Sensory Meltdown		
PHASE	OBSERVABLE FACIAL & AUTONOMIC BIOMARKERS	PARENT INTERCEPTION PROTOCOL (DO THIS IMMEDIATELY)
Phase 1: Green (Regulated)	Relaxed facial muscles, reciprocal smiling, steady eye contact, rhythmic calm breathing, responsive to verbal cues.	Normal engagement, verbal instruction, standard classroom expectations.
Phase 2: Amber (Prodromal Overload) 10-15 Min Before Meltdown	• Micro-furrowing between eyebrows (corrugator supercilii) • Pupils dilated; eyes darting around room • Rapid shallow breathing; clenched fists or jaw • Verbal answers become monosyllabic ("Fine", "No") • Increased repetitive pacing or rocking	INTERVENE NOW: 1. Immediately remove current academic/task demand. 2. Silence your talking (auditory brain is shutting down). 3. Offer sensory exit: dim room, headphones, cold water drink.
Phase 3: Red (Full Meltdown)	Prefrontal cortex offline; fight-or-flight sympathetic storm; screaming, thrashing, bolting, sensory panic.	SAFETY ONLY: Zero discipline. Zero reasoning. Keep child physically safe from sharp objects. Sit quietly nearby providing calm co-regulation.

Clinical Insight: Intervening during Phase 2 (Amber) prevents 80% of Phase 3 meltdowns. Once a child reaches Phase 3, you cannot talk them down—you must wait for the hormonal adrenaline surge to clear.